



options to outsmart bowlers. Batting as a craft once revered shots played along the ground, targeting 'the V' in front — safe and risk-averse. But the modern siege by batters has opened avenues behind the wicket too, through fine leg and third man regions.

Runs in the fine-leg region have seen an astronomical surge. In 2022, across all T20s, batters accumulated at a strike rate of 107.53 through fine leg. In the three years since (2023, 2024, 2025), the lowest strike rate through fine leg has been 195.96, in 2024.

The scoring rate through third man is not as skewed, but has still seen an uptick since the turn of the decade. Batters have pocketed runs at strike rates in excess of 185, compared to pre-2020 figures that hovered between 160-170.

The runs flowing in torrents behind square, on either side, are a result of batters giving innovation a shot. It is also partly an attempt to

nullify any advantage for the bowler. As bowling units have put more emphasis on match-ups, particularly with spinners, batters have reverted to options that help them play with the turn — even if that has translated to putting a lower price on their wicket.

In T20s since 2021, right-handed batters have deployed the reverse sweep at least 200 times against leg-spinners every year. In 2025, it was used 335 times. Before 2020, its most frequent use came in 2018 (168 times). Southpaws have embraced the reverse sweep too, trusting it more often against off-spinners and left-arm unorthodox bowlers.

The use of the switch hit and scoop has more than doubled since 2021. In the wake of this no-holds-barred modus operandi, bowlers have been forced to adapt. Playing shots behind square requires pace, and the quicks have responded by not offering any at all.

A well-disguised slower delivery

Smooth operator: In T20s since 2021, right-handed batters have deployed the reverse sweep at least 200 times against leg-spinners every year.

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has always been a refuge for pacers in T20 cricket, but its use has surged of late. And the change-up is no longer merely about taking pace off; pacers have leaned heavily on their cutters. In T20Is in 2025, the off-cutter was used more than 1,600 times by pacers — its most frequent use to date — dragging the batting strike rate down to 134.05.

That Jasprit Bumrah, one of the quickest in the game, has been the most frugal proponent of the off-cutter is indicative of its growing popularity against modern willow-wielders. The Indian pacer has deployed it 49 times since July 2025, conceding under six runs per over and picking up five wickets.

The leg-cutter was more sparsely